BASEL, SWITZERLAND

Kunstmuseum Basel: Masterpieces

Twenty works in which a figure or object remains identifiable under very different kinds of pressure.



Holbein gives Christ’s body almost no space beyond its own length. Klee needs only a few divided colours and signs to make a face. Between these two extremes lies a productive question: what must a picture retain for a body to remain present? The answer can be physical weight, an arrangement of features, a gesture or the small clues left by a fragmented object.

This selection does not propose a simple march from realism to abstraction. Braque’s early harbour and later still lifes alone would complicate it. Instead, it brings different methods into proximity, asking what each makes available and what it deliberately holds back.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/kunstmuseum-basel

The selection · 20

1. The Body of the Dead Christ in the Tomb
   Hans Holbein the Younger · 1521–1522
2. Study for the Family Portrait of Thomas More
   Hans Holbein the Younger · c. 1527
3. Synagoga
   Konrad Witz · 1435
4. Saint Christopher
   Konrad Witz · 1435
5. Senecio
   Paul Klee · 1922
6. The Burning Giraffe
   Salvador Dalí · 1937
7. Still Life BACH
   Georges Braque · 1912
8. Violin and Pitcher
   Georges Braque · 1910
9. Pedestal
   Pablo Picasso · 1914
10. Self-Portrait
    Marc Chagall · 1914
11. The Cattle Dealer
    Marc Chagall · 1912
12. The Muse Inspiring the Poet
    Henri Rousseau · 1909
13. The Dents du Midi from Chesières
    Ferdinand Hodler · 1912
14. Lake Geneva from Chexbres
    Ferdinand Hodler · 1905
15. Antwerp Harbour
    Georges Braque · 1905
16. Little Girl in a Black Apron
    Amedeo Modigliani · 1918
17. A Mortally Wounded Brigand Quenches His Thirst
    Eugène Delacroix · 1825
18. Stafelalp: Return of the Animals
    Ernst Ludwig Kirchner · 1919
19. Battle of the Centaurs
    Arnold Böcklin · 1873
20. Boy with a Cat
    Paula Modersohn-Becker · c. 1903

01 / 20

The Body of the Dead Christ in the Tomb

Hans Holbein the Younger

1521–1522 · Kunstmuseum Basel



Hans Holbein the Younger. The Body of the Dead Christ in the Tomb. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The recess gives the body scarcely any room, and no living mourner mediates the encounter. Mouth, hands and feet remain exposed within the narrow format. Even the apparently definite date has a history: the museum’s technical study found that Holbein altered 1522 to 1521 while completing the work, now dated to 1521–1522.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Study for the Family Portrait of Thomas More

Hans Holbein the Younger

c. 1527 · Kunstmuseum Basel



Hans Holbein the Younger. Study for the Family Portrait of Thomas More. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/hans-holbein-the-younger/study-for-the-family-portrait-of-thomas-more · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The household has to become a group without losing its separate members. Lightly drawn details and notes make that problem visible at the planning stage. The spaces between seated and standing figures matter as much as individual outlines: likeness will have to operate within an arrangement capable of holding several people together.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Synagoga

Konrad Witz

1435 · Kunstmuseum Basel



Konrad Witz. The Synagogue. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The gold robe gives the figure material splendour, but the blindfold, broken staff and tablets impose a Christian allegory of Judaism. Their meaning should not be mistaken for a neutral account of Jewish belief. Witz makes the personification persuasive as a body while participating in a religious hierarchy that the image asks the spectator to accept.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Saint Christopher

Konrad Witz

1435 · Kunstmuseum Basel



Konrad Witz. St. Christopher. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The large carrier bends under a child whose apparent size cannot explain the effort. Staff, footing and drapery make the imbalance bodily rather than merely a fact supplied by the title. The river crossing becomes a test of weight: the image requires the saint to carry more than ordinary appearances would suggest.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Senecio

Paul Klee

1922 · Oil on canvas · Kunstmuseum Basel



Senecio. WikiArt; Paul Klee. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Red eyes and unequal geometric features are enough to establish a face within the divided circle. Recognition arrives quickly, but the coloured areas keep offering another kind of arrangement. Klee does not erase the person completely. He leaves the spectator moving between the head as a whole and the independent pieces from which it is assembled.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

The Burning Giraffe

Salvador Dalí

1937 · Oil on panel · Kunstmuseum Basel



Salvador Dalí. The Burning Giraffe. WikiArt source label: Salvador Dali Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/salvador-dali/flaming-giraffe · Salvador Dali Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Drawers open from the tall blue figure, while supports extend behind it. The distant burning animal is smaller than the title might lead one to expect. The impossible anatomy remains clearly described, which gives the scene its particular difficulty: the parts are legible, but they refuse to add up to an ordinary functioning body.

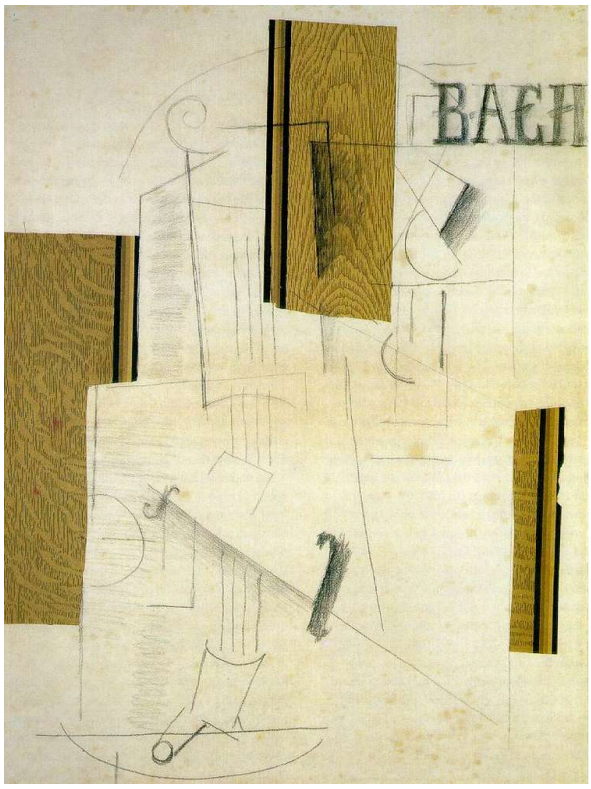
Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Still Life BACH

Georges Braque

1912 · Charcoal, collage and gouache on paper · Kunstmuseum Basel



Georges Braque. Still life BACH. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/georges-braque/still-life-bach-1912 · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

Letters, drawn fragments and applied paper identify a still life without agreeing on one continuous depth. Each material can contribute a different kind of clue. Rather than treating the paper as a failed imitation of an object, the picture allows it to remain paper while taking a place in the construction.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Violin and Pitcher

Georges Braque

1910 · Oil on canvas · Kunstmuseum Basel



Georges Braque. Violin and pitcher. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/georges-braque/violin-and-pitcher-1910 · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

The violin and pitcher do not present themselves from a single secure viewpoint. Fragments emerge among brown and grey planes, then return to the larger arrangement. The title helps establish what is being sought, but it does not remove the work of recognition. Objects and painted divisions compete for the same attention.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Pedestal

Pablo Picasso

1914 · Oil on canvas · Kunstmuseum Basel



Pablo Picasso. Pedestal. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/pedestal-1914 · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

The pale rectangle interrupts a narrow gathering of lines, letters and patterned shapes. None needs to behave like a fully modelled object for the arrangement to suggest a still life. The important tension is between recognisable clues and the flat areas that contain them; do not assume every patterned fragment represents an actual piece of collage.

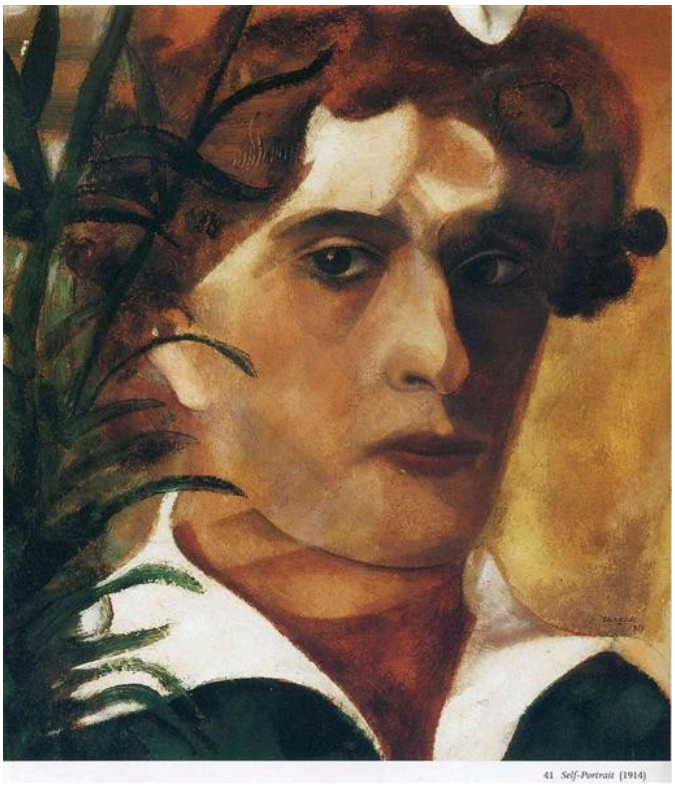
Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Self-Portrait

Marc Chagall

1914 · Oil on cardboard mounted on canvas · Kunstmuseum Basel



Marc Chagall. Self-Portrait. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The face is close and comparatively easy to read, though warm and cool areas divide its shadows. Foliage-like forms press beside the head. Set near *The Cattle Dealer*, this self-portrait prevents one pictorial method from standing for everything Chagall did: the degree of invention changes with the particular image.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Im 1081

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The Cattle Dealer

Marc Chagall

1912 · Oil on canvas · Kunstmuseum Basel



Marc Chagall. The Cattle Dealer. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

An animal’s interior appears alongside what can ordinarily be seen from outside it. Around the cart and horse, figures occupy unusual angles within the coloured terrain. The picture does not maintain a single rule for visibility. Observation and imagined knowledge share the surface, making the journey more than a coherent view from one position.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2213

12 / 20

The Muse Inspiring the Poet

Henri Rousseau

1909 · Oil on canvas · Kunstmuseum Basel



The Muse Inspiring the Poet. WikiArt; Henri Rousseau. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The figures stand with the stillness of a formal portrait, but oversized flowers complicate their relation to the garden. Repeated outlines connect people and plants across the scene. Rather than correcting the scale into a plausible place, follow what its inequality does: it makes the literary pairing belong to an invented setting.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

The Dents du Midi from Chesières

Ferdinand Hodler

1912 · Oil on canvas · Kunstmuseum Basel



Ferdinand Hodler. The Dents du Midi from Chesieres. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/ferdinand-hodler/the-dents-du-midi-from-chesieres-1912 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The mountain’s profile survives the removal of most small detail. Blue slopes, pale cloud and warmer sky establish its position through broad divisions. Compared with the crowded bodies elsewhere in this selection, Hodler leaves little to identify one feature at a time. Recognition is carried by the outline of the whole ridge.

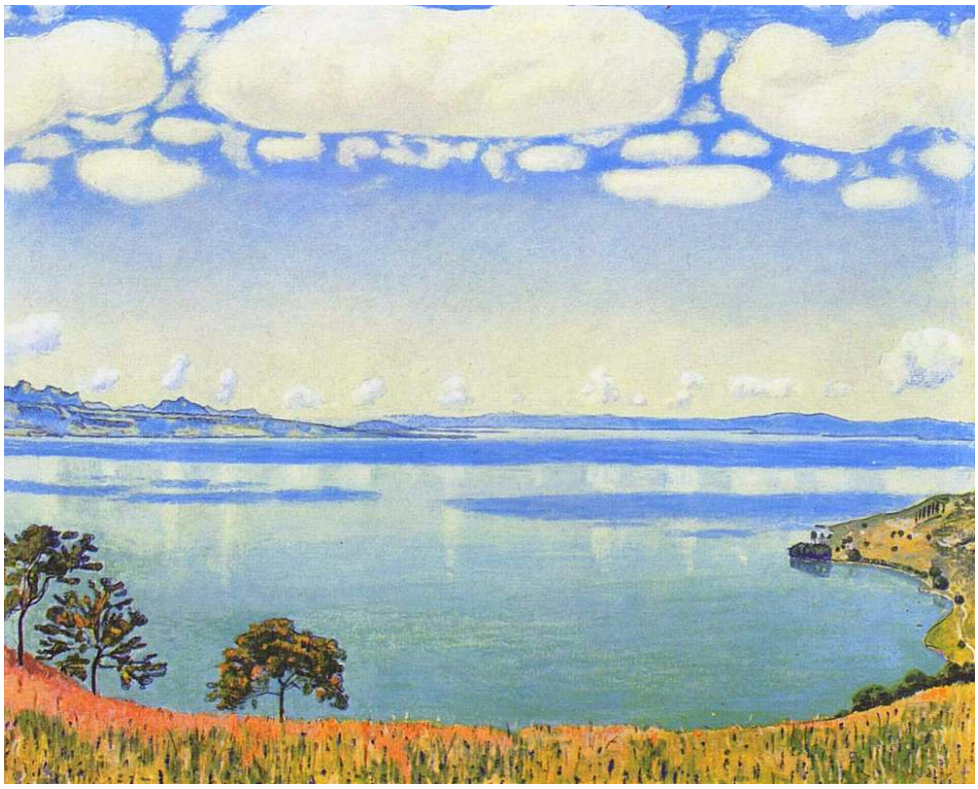
Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

Lake Geneva from Chexbres

Ferdinand Hodler

1905 · Oil on canvas · Kunstmuseum Basel



Ferdinand Hodler. View of Lake Leman from Chexbres. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/ferdinand-hodler/view-of-lake-leman-from-chexbres-1905 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Cloud forms repeat above horizontal passages of reflection, giving sky and water a visible relation. Trees and the narrow near ground establish a viewing position without competing in scale with the lake. The landscape remains a place, but its repetitions also make it readable as an ordered surface.

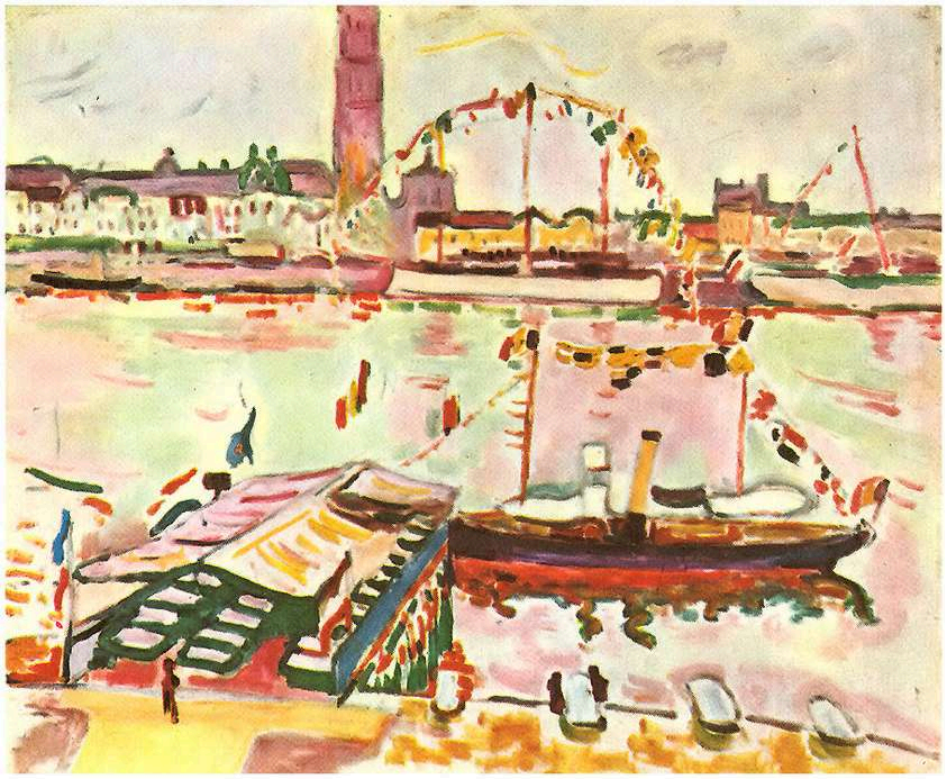
Object source · Open artwork

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Antwerp Harbour

Georges Braque

1905 · Oil on canvas · Kunstmuseum Basel



Georges Braque. Antwerp Harbor. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/georges-braque/antwerp-harbor-1905 · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

The harbour is built from separated bright strokes with pale ground showing between them. Boats, buildings and chimney remain identifiable without a continuously filled setting. Beside Braque’s later *Violin and Pitcher*, this work provides a useful comparison of methods: broken colour here, fragmented planes there, both loosening an apparently stable view.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Little Girl in a Black Apron

Amedeo Modigliani

1918 · Oil on canvas · Kunstmuseum Basel



Amedeo Modigliani. Little Girl in Black Apron. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/amedeo-modigliani/little-girl-in-black-apron-1918 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The girl’s head tilts above a narrow neck while her lowered arms support a frontal pose. That slight departure from symmetry is more informative than an invented account of her mood. It gives a particular adjustment to a simplified body, allowing the sitter to remain distinct within Modigliani’s economical handling of faces and figures.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

A Mortally Wounded Brigand Quenches His Thirst

Eugène Delacroix

1825 · Oil on canvas · Kunstmuseum Basel



Eugène Delacroix. A Mortally Wounded Brigand Quenches his Thirst. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/eugene-delacroix/a-mortally-wounded-brigand-quenches-his-thirst-1825 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Drinking becomes the wounded man’s urgent task. His pale face and sleeve separate him from the rough ground without lifting him out of it. The dramatic title supplies a condition the image cannot fully explain by itself; the visible action narrows attention to a bodily need that survives whatever story brought him there.

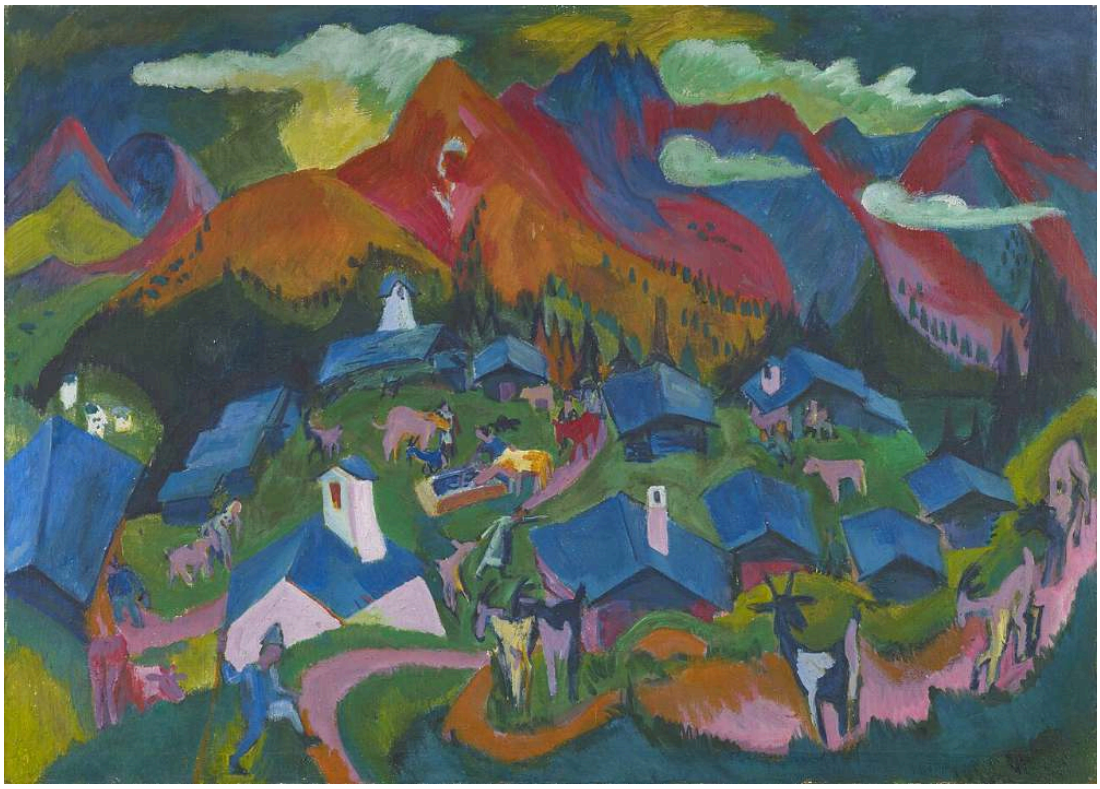
Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Stafelalp: Return of the Animals

Ernst Ludwig Kirchner

1919 · Oil on canvas · Kunstmuseum Basel



Ernst Ludwig Kirchner. Stafelalp, Rückkehr der Tiere (1919). Kunstmuseum Basel; Schenkung Eberhard W. Kornfeld. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Kirchner_-_Stafelalp%2C_R%C3%BCckkehr_der_Tiere%2C_1919%2C_Inv._G_2017.10.jpg. Accessed 2026-09-18T07:59:53Z. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop or generated content. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The returning animals and figures move through a landscape divided into emphatic patches of colour. Houses and mountains supply strong directional changes rather than a neutral backdrop. The familiar rural action remains possible to follow, but its route is inseparable from the way Kirchner has reorganised the slopes around it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: G 2017.10

19 / 20

Battle of the Centaurs

Arnold Böcklin

1873 · Kunstmuseum Basel



Arnold Böcklin. Battle of the Centaurs. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The centaurs' combined anatomies give the struggle more points of collision: raised stones, bent human limbs and the weight of horse bodies converge. Myth supplies the creatures, but the violence depends on physical relations. Bodies need room and meet resistance, even in a scene whose participants cannot exist.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Boy with a Cat

Paula Modersohn-Becker

c. 1903 · Kunstmuseum Basel



Paula Modersohn-Becker. Boy with Cat. Image credit: Paula Modersohn-Becker; Source credit: Kunstmuseum Basel. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The child’s arms contain the pale cat against dark clothing. With few surrounding details, that act of holding becomes the portrait’s central relation. Broad shapes give both bodies solidity without asking either face to perform affection. Care can be described through support and contact rather than a compulsory smile.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1749

Compare methods, not a ladder of progress

The three Braques are a useful small sequence, while Holbein, Klee and Modersohn-Becker offer three markedly different accounts of a body. Follow those differences without ranking detail above simplification. Check the museum's current information for display availability; this order is editorial, not a route through its buildings.

Further reading

Concerning the Spiritual in Art

Wassily Kandinsky; translated by Michael Sadleir · Read free · English

Kandinsky's discussion of colour and form belongs to the period in which several modern works here were made. It offers one argument to test against Klee, Chagall and Braque's very different approaches.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12
